

Evidence Room

Agents that earn responsibility.

AP Agent Starter — Operating Guide

Operating model, ten condensed blueprints, and a 90-day path from diagnosis to disciplined pilot.

SKU ER-START-79 · \$79 · Individual / practitioner licence

v1.0 · Commercial pack · Not legal advice · Not a software runtime

1. What Starter is (and is not)

Starter is a governed introduction to AP agents for Controllers and AP practitioners: an operating model, human-vs-agent RACI patterns, ten condensed blueprints (A01–A10), a transform roadmap, and an implementation checklist.

It is not hosted AP software, not a prompt marketplace, and not authorisation to release payments. If you need full control matrices, testing scripts, and A11–A16 depth, that is Pro. Multi-seat change management is Team. ERP-specific design is Custom.

2. Operating model essentials

Invoice Case as the unit of work

Treat each invoice as an Invoice Case with status, evidence pointers, exception codes, owners, and stage history. Agents write to the case; humans remain accountable for money movement. Cases prevent chat residue from becoming the system of record.

Charter before code

Every agent needs a charter: purpose, inputs/outputs, allowed stages, forbidden actions, evidence standard, pilot KPIs, and kill-switch. Copy the Starter charter stub and fill invoice classes before any production use.

Human responsibilities that never move

- Payment authorisation and release
- Vendor bank detail changes
- SoD conflict resolution
- Representations to auditors
- Stage promotion decisions

3. Human vs agent framework

Work type	Human	Agent (earn-up dependent)
Policy interpretation	Owens meaning and exceptions	May draft summaries of policy hits
Master-data change	Owens and dual-controls	May flag anomalies; never silent write
Match within tolerance	Samples and overrides	May propose; later bounded execute if earned
Supplier communication	Edits, approves, sends	May draft packs with citations
Payment release	Always human	Propose only (Pro A12 pattern)
Audit representation	Always human	May assemble evidence index

4. Earn-up in Starter practice

Starter deployments typically stop at Propose. Bounded execute is a Pro-era decision after earn-in samples. Demotion remains available at every stage.

- Observe: coverage and noise review
- Recommend: precision sample + owner accept
- Draft: edit-distance / QA sample
- Propose: mandatory human confirm for money-adjacent actions

5. Agent blueprints A01–A05

A01 Invoice Intake

Purpose: Capture, classify, extract, enrich into Invoice Cases. **Stage path:** Observe → Draft → Propose. **Forbidden:** Changing bank details; inventing PO numbers.

A02 Invoice Validation

Purpose: Structural and master-data checks before matching. **Stage path:** Observe → Propose holds/fixes. **Forbidden:** Silent master-data writes.

A03 Matching

Purpose: 2-/3-way match within published tolerances. **Stage path:** Propose; bounded execute only after earn-in. **Forbidden:** Silent override of price/qty failures.

A04 Exception Triage

Purpose: Classify, prioritise, route with taxonomy codes. **Stage path:** Draft → Propose assignment. **Forbidden:** Closing exceptions without policy; payment release.

A05 Goods Receipt

Purpose: Signal GR completeness and timing blockers. **Stage path:** Observe → Propose follow-ups. **Forbidden:** Fabricating GR documents.

6. Agent blueprints A06–A10

A06 PO Quality

Purpose: Detect PO hygiene issues that create preventable mismatches. **Stage path:** Observe → Draft tickets.
Forbidden: Unilateral PO changes.

A07 Approval

Purpose: Route approval packets per policy without breaking SoD. **Stage path:** Propose → bounded execute after earn-in.
Forbidden: Self-approval loops; skipping required approvers.

A08 Supplier Resolution

Purpose: Prepare external clarification packs. **Stage path:** Draft → Propose send. **Forbidden:** Promising payment dates not in system.

A09 Internal Follow-Up

Purpose: Chase internal owners against SLAs. **Stage path:** Draft → Propose; bounded reminders after earn-in.
Forbidden: Harassing channels outside policy.

A10 Duplicate / Anomaly

Purpose: Emit duplicate and anomaly signals for investigation. **Stage path:** Propose holds; human investigates.
Forbidden: Auto-voiding; asserting fraud certainty.

Pro extends the library to A11–A16 (statements, payment proposal, close, reporting, root cause, orchestrator).

7. Cross-cutting rules

- No agent writes bank details.
- Starter deployments do not authorise or release payments.
- Every production run writes evidence.
- Stage promotion requires sampled performance review — not enthusiasm.
- A10 emits signals only — never market as guaranteed fraud detection.
- Do not claim guaranteed cost/invoice reduction; industry context only via Ardent Partners 2025 (\$9.84, 18.4% exceptions, 35.4% STP).

8. 90-day transform path (illustrative)

Days	Focus	Exit criteria
0–14	Baseline KPIs; taxonomy; charter for one agent	Written pilot charter + kill-switch
15–45	Shadow Observe → Draft on one channel / org	Evidence pack quality review
46–75	Propose stage with mandatory human confirm	KPI movement with controls intact
76–90	Retrospective; promote/demote; roadmap to Pro	Board-ready pilot report

9. Implementation checklist

Before shadow mode

- Owners named for agent, control, and KPI
- Sandbox available
- Exception taxonomy published
- Evidence storage path defined
- Kill-switch tested
- Internal Audit informed of pilot scope

During Propose

- 100% human confirmation for money-adjacent actions
- Weekly sample of false positives/negatives
- Override log reviewed
- No silent prompt changes

Before any bounded execute (usually Pro)

- Earn-in sample meets precision bar
- Invoice class whitelist published
- Demotion trigger defined
- Controller sign-off recorded

10. Pilot KPI template

Type	KPI	Baseline	Success signal	Non-goal
Primary				Guaranteed \$ savings
Secondary				
Control (must not worsen)			e.g. on-time pay / audit findings	Fraud certainty claims

11. Common failure modes

- Piloting three agents at once with no taxonomy
- Skipping evidence packs because 'the model is good'
- Letting processors paste invoices into personal LLM chats
- Promising the board cost/invoice equal to survey averages
- Treating A10 hits as confirmed fraud

12. When to upgrade

Move to Pro when you need full control matrices, deeper playbooks, testing packs, and business-case models. Move to Team when multiple seats need shared RACI and change packs. Engage Custom when ERP object models or edge policies require bespoke design.

Disclaimer

Evidence Room provides methodologies, diagnostics, and design artefacts. We do not guarantee cost reduction, ROI, fraud prevention, or audit outcomes. Industry benchmarks attributed to Ardent Partners (2025) — average cost per invoice **\$9.84**, exception rate **18.4%**, STP **35.4%** — are third-party reference points only and are not Evidence Room performance claims. Agents must operate under your controls, policies, and human accountability. Evidence Room is not your ERP vendor, bank, or auditor.

AI agents can be wrong. Humans remain accountable for approvals, postings, payments, supplier master changes, and representations to auditors and regulators.

Appendix — Evidence pack checklist (1)

Every material agent decision should leave an evidence pack an auditor can follow.

This appendix reinforces Evidence Room operating discipline. It is educational and does not modify your licence, create warranties, or guarantee operational outcomes.

- Inputs used and source system references
- Rule or model version hash
- Confidence or variance table
- Human override identity and rationale
- Timestamp and Invoice Case ID
- Kill-switch status at time of action

Remember: Observe → Recommend → Draft → Execute (narrow) → Expand. Demotion is hygiene. Ardent Partners (2025) benchmarks are third-party survey averages for context only.

Operating note 1: maintain named owners for agent, control, and KPI. Refuse unsupervised payment release. Keep evidence packs complete. Review overrides weekly. Treat silence in logging as a defect.

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Appendix — Kill-switch protocol (2)

A kill-switch is useless if nobody has rehearsed it.

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- Named operators
- Disable write paths first
- Notify AP Manager / Controls / IT
- Record demotion stage
- Preserve logs
- Retest after prompt/model change

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Appendix — Sample QA method (3)

Sampling beats vibes. Define sample size and demotion trigger before Propose.

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- Stratified samples by invoice class
- Score TP/FP/TN/FN
- Publish weekly precision
- Demote on consecutive misses
- Label worksheets ILLUSTRATIVE until measured
- Never substitute Ardent averages for your pass bar

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Appendix — SoD reminders (4)

Speed is not a reason to collapse segregation of duties.

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- Vendor setup ≠ entry ≠ payment release
- Bank changes dual control
- Agents never self-approve
- Force-pay limited and logged
- Access reviews annually
- Document compensating controls

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